

THE MONKEY'S PAW

A Story in Three Scenes

by W. W. Jacobs, dramatised by Louis N. Parker

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CHARACTERS

MR. WHITE

MRS. WHITE

HERBERT, their son

SERGEANT-MAJOR MORRIS

MR. SAMPSON

First produced at the Haymarket Theatre, London, October 6, 1903.

SCENE I

Scznz.--The living-room of an old-fashioned cottage on the outskirts of Fulham.

Set corner-wis in the left angle at the back is a deep window; rther front, L., three or four steps lead up to a or. Farther forward is a dresser, with plates, glusses, etc. B.O. at back \: 4m alcove with the street door fully visible. On '\- neside of

* the street door is a wire letter-box. CG.ue R. i8 @ cupboard, then a fireplace. In the O. is a round table. Against the wall, u. back, is an old-fashioned piano. A comfortable armchair is on each side of the fireplace. There are other chairs. On the mantel- piece are @ clock, ola china figures, etc. An air of comfort pervades the room.

At the rise of the Curtarx, Mrs, Wars, a pleasant- looking old woman, is seated in the armchair below the fire, attending to a kettle which is steaming on the fire, and keeping a laughing eye on Mr. White and Herbert. These tu are seated at the R. angle of the table ».earest the 2 with a chess-board between them. Mr. Wuire: 'vidently losing. His hair is ruffled; his spectucles are high up on his forehead. Herbert. @ fixe young fellow, is looking with satixicction a: the move he has just made. Mr. WI :.i makea several attempts to move, but thinks

better of them. There is a shaded lamp on the table.

_ The door is tightly shut. 'The curtains of the window are drawn; but every now and then the wind is

heard whistling outside.

MR. WHITE: (moving at last and triumphant). There, Herbert, my boy! Got you, I think.
Herbert. Oh, you're a deep 'un, Dad, aren't you?

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MRS. WHITE: Mean to say he's beaten you at last?

HERBERT: Lor, no! Why, he's overlooked--

MR. WHITE: (very excited). I see it! Lemme have that back!

HERBERT: Not much. Rules of the game!

MR. WHITE: (disgusted). I don't hold with them scientific rules. You turn what ought to be an innocent relaxation

MRS. WHITE: Don't talk so much, Father. You put him off--

HERBERT: (laughing). Not he!

MR. WHITE: (trying to distract his attention). Hark at the wind.

HERBERT: (dryly). Ah! I'm listening. Check.

MR. WHITE: (still trying to distract him). I should hardly think Sergeant-Major Morris'd come to. night.

HERBERT: Mate, (He rises and goes up L.)

MR. WHITE: (with an outbreak of disgust and sweeping the chessmen off the board). That's the worst of living so far out. Your friends can't come for a quiet chat, and you addle your brains over @ con-founded--

HERBERT: Now, Father! Morris'll turn up all right.

as WAITE (still in a temper). Lovers' Lane, Fulham! Ho! Of all the beastly, slushy, out-o'-the-way places to live in-- I Pathway's a bog, and the road's a torrent,

MRS. WHITE: Never mind, dear. Perhaps you'll win to-morrow. (She moves to the back of the table.) Mr. White. Perhaps T'll--perhaps []-- 1 What d'you mean? (He bursts out laughing.) Thero!

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You always know what's going on inside o' me, don't you, Mother?

MRS. WHITE: Ought to, after thirty years, John. (She goes to the dresser, and busies herself wiping tumblers on the tray there.)

(He rises, goes to the fireplace and lights his pipe.)

HERBERT: (down c.). And it's not such a bad place, Dad, after all. One of the few old-fashioned houses left near London. None o' your stucco villas. Home- like, I call it. And so do you, or you wouldn't ha' bought it. (He rolls a cigarette.);

MR. WHITE: (B., growling). Nice job I made o' that, too! With two hundred pounds owin' on it.

HERBERT: (on the back of a chair, c.). Why, I shall work that off in no time, Dad. Matter o' three years, with the rise promised me.

MR. WHITE: If you don't get married.

HERBERT: Not me. Not that sort.

MRS. WHITE: I wish you would, Herbert. <A good, steady lad--

(She brings the tray with a bottle of whisky, glasses, & lemon, spoons, buns, and a knife to the table.)

HERBERT: Lots o' time, Mother. Sufficient for the day--as the sayin' goes. Just now my dynamos don't leave me any time for love-making. Jealous, they are, I tell you!

MR. WHITE: (chuckling). I lay awake o' night often, and think: If Herbert took a nap, and let his what- d'you-call-ums--dynamos, run down, all Fulham would be in darkness. Lord! what a joke! (He

goes B.C.) Herbert. Joke! And me with the sack! Pretty

idea of a joke you've got, I don't think. (A knock is heard at the outer door.) Mrs. White. Hark! (The knock is repeated, louder.)

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MR. WHITE: (going towards the door). That's him. That's the Sergeant-Major. (He unlocks the door, back.)

HERBERT: (removes the chess-board). Wonder what yarn he's got for us to-night. (He places the chess. board on the piano.)

MRS. WHITE: (goes up RB. and busies herself putting the other armchair nearer the fire, etc.). Don't let the door slam, John!

(Mr. White opens the door a little, struggling with it. Wind. SERGEANT-Major Morkris, a veteran with a distinct military appearance--left arm gone-- dressed as a commissionaire, is seen to enter. Mr. Warts helps him off with his coat, which he hangs up in the outer hall.)

MR. WHITE: (at the door). Slip in quick! It's as much as I can do to hold it against the wind.

SERGEANT: Awful! Awful I (Busy taking off his cloak, etc.) And a mile up the road--by the ceme. tery--it's worse. Enough to blow the hair off your head.

MR. WHITE: Give me your stick.

SERGEANT: If 'twasn't I knew what a welcome I'd get--

MR. WHITE: (preceding him into the room). Sergeant- Major Morris!

MRS. WHITE: Tut! tut! So cold you must be! Come to the fire; do'ee, now.

SERGEANT: How are you, marm? (7'o Herbert.) How's yourself, laddie?° Not on duty yet, eh? Day- week, eh?

HERBERT: (c.). No, sir. Night-week. But there's half an hour yet.

(Mr. Wurre mize: grog for Morris.)

SERGEANT: (sitting in the armchair above the fire, which Mrs. White. is motic ing him towards). "Thank'ee kindly, marm. That's good--hah! That's a sight better than the trenches at Chitral, That's

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better than settin' in puddle with the rain pourin' down in buckets, and the natives takin' pot-shots at you.

MRS. WHITE: Didn't you have no umbrellas? (She is at the corner below the fire, and kneels before it, stirs tt, etc.)

SERGEANT: Umbrell? Ho! ho! That's good! Eh, White? That's good. Did ye hear what she said? Umbrellas!-- And goloshes! and hot-water bottles!--Ho, yes! No offence, marm, but it's easy to see you was never a soldier.

HERBERT: (rather hurt). Mother spoke out o' kind- ness, sir.

SERGEANT: And well I know it; and no offence intended. No, marm, 'ardship, 'ardship is the soldier's lot. Starvation, fever, and get yourself shot. That's a bit o' my own.

MRS. WHITE: You don't look to've taken much

harm (She indicates his empty sleeve. She ta the' kettle to the table, then returns to the fire.)

SERGEANT: (showing a medal hidden under his coat). ~And that I got this for. No, marm. Tough. Thomas Morris is tough.

(Mz. Waite is holding a glass of grog wnder the Sergeant'S nose.)

And sober. What's this now?

MR. WHITE: Put your nose in it; you'll see.

Sera@Eant. Whisky? And hot? And sugar? And a slice o' lemon? No. I said I'd never--but seein' the sort o' night. Well! (Waving the glass at them.) Here's another thousand a year!

MR. WHITE: (sits R. of the table, also with a glass). Same to you, and many of 'em.

SERGEANT: (to Herbert, who has no glass). What? Not you? :

HERBERT: (laughing and sitting across his chair, ©.). Oh! 'tisn't for want of being sociable. But my work don't go with it. Not if 'twas ever so little. I've

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MRS. WHITE: Don't, Herbert. (She sits in the armchair below the fire.)

HERBERT: (laughing). No fear, Mother.

SERGEANT: Ah! you electricians!--Sort o' magi- cians, you are. Light! says you--and light it is. And, power! says you--and the trams go whizzin'. And, knowledge! says you--and words go 'ummin' to the ends o' the world. It fair beats me--and I've seen a bit in my time, too.

HERBERT: (nudges his father). Your Indian magic? All. a fake, governor. The fakir's fake.

SERGEANT: Fake, you call it? I tell you, I've seen it.

HERBERT: (nudging his father with his foot). Oh, come, now! such as what? Come, now!

SERGEANT: I've seen a cove with no more clothes on than a babby, (to Mrs. White) if you know what I mean--take an empty basket--empty, mind!--as empty as--as this here glass--

MR. WHITE: Hand it over, Morris. (He hands it to Herbert, who goes quickly behind the table and fills it.)

SERGEANT: Which was not my intentions, but used for illustration.

HERBERT: (while mixing). Oh, I've seen the basket trick; and I've read how it was done. Why, I could do it myself, with a bit o' practice. Ladle out something stronger.

(Herbert brings him the glass.)

SERGEANT: Stronger?--what do you say to an old fakir chuckin' a rope up in the air--in the atr, mind you!--and swarming up it, same as if it was *ooked on--and vanishing clean out o' sight?--I've seen that. : :

(Herbert goes to the table, plunges a knife into a bun and offers it to the SERGEANT with exaggerated politeness.)

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(Eyeing it with disgust.) Bun--? What for? Herbert. That yarn takes it.

(Mr. and Mrs. Wurre are delighted.)

SERGEANT: Mean to say you doubt my word?

MRS. WHITE: No, no! He's only taking you off.--You shouldn't, Herbert.

MR. WHITE: Herbert always was one for a bit o' fun!

(Herbert puts the bun back on the table, comes round in front and, moving the chair out of the way sits cross-legged on the floor at his father's side.)

SERGEANT: i it it's true. Why, if I chose, I could tell you things--_ But there! wou don't get no more yarns out o' me.

MR. WHITE: Nonsense, old friend. 'He puts down his glass.) You're not going to get shirty about a bit o' fun. (He moves his chair nearer Morpis's.) What was that you started telling me the other day about a monkey's paw, or something? (He nudges Herbert. and winks at Mrs. WHITE.)

SERGEANT: (gravely). Nothing. Leastways, nothing worth hearing.

MRS. WHITE: (with astonished curiosity). Monkey s paw--?

MR. WHITE: Ah--you ~ae tellin'? me--

SERGEANT: Nothing. Don't go cu about it. (He puts his empty glass to his lips--then stares at it.) What? Empty again? There! When I begin thinkin' o' the paw, it makes mc that absent-minded--

M:. WHITE (rises and fills the glass. Y aid you always ca:Tied it on you.

SERGEANT: Sol do, for fear o' what might happen. (Sunk in thought.) Ay!--ay!

MR. WHITE: (handing him his glass refilled), 'There. (He sits again in the same chair.)

MRS. WHITE: What's it for?

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HERBERT: I will, every word.

SERGEANT: Magic, then!--Don't you laugh I Herbert. I'm not. Got it on you now? Sergeant. Of course.

HERBERT: Let's see it.

(Seeing the SeRGEant embarrassed with his glass, Mrs. White. rises, takes it from him, places it on the mantelpirce and remains stand; g.)

SERGEANT: Oh, it's nothing to look at. (Hunting in his pocket.) Just an ordinary--little paw--dried to & mummy. (Produces it and holds it towards Mrs. Wart.) Here.

MRS. WHITE: (who has leant forward eagerly to see it, starts back with a little cry of disgust). Oh!

HERBERT: Give us a look.

(Morris passes the paw to Mr. Warre, from whom Herbert takes it.) Why, it's all dried up! Sergeant. I said so.

Mrs. Warre (with a slight shudder). Hark at the wind! (She sits again in her old place.)

MR. WHITE: (taking the paw from Herbert.) And what might there be special about it?

SERGEANT: (impressively). That there paw has had a spell put upon it!

MR. WHITE: No? (In great alarm he thrusts the paw back into Morris's hand.)

SERGEANT: (pensively, holding the paw in the palm of his hand). Ah! By an old fakir. He was a very holy man. He'd sat all doubled up in one spot, goin' on for fifteen years; thinkin' of things. And he wanted to show that fate ruled people. That every- thing was cut and dried from the beginning, as you might say. That there warn't no gettin' away from

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it. And that, if you tried to, you caught it hot. (He pauses solemnly.) So he put a spell on this bit of a paw. It might have been anything else, but he took the first thing that came handy. Ah! He put a spell on it, and made it so that three people (looking at them and with deep meaning) could each have three wishes.

(All but Mrs. Warre laugh rather nervously.)

MRS. WHITE: Ssa! Don't!

SERGEANT: (more gravely) But--! But, mark you, though the wishes were granted, those three people would have cause to wish they hadn't been.

MR. WHITE: But how could the wishes be granted?

SERGEANT: He didn't say. It would all happen so natural, you might think it a coincidence if so disposed.

HERBERT: Why haven't you tried it, sir?

SERGEANT: (gravely, after a pause). I have.

Herbert (eagerly). You've had your three wishes?

SERGEANT: (gravely). Yes.

MRS. WHITE: Were they granted?

SuRGEAnt (staring at the fire). They were.

(A pause.) Mr. White. Has anybody else wished? Sergeant. Yes. The first owner had his three wish (Lost in recollection.) Yes, ob ves, he had his three wishes all right. I don't know what his first two were, (very impressively) but the third was for death. (AU shudder.) That's how I got the paw.

(A pause.) Herbert. (cheerfully). Well! Seems to me you've only got to wish for things that can't have any bad luck about 'em-- (He rises.)

SERGEANT: (shaking his head). Ah! Mr. White. (tentatively). Morris--if you've had

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your three wishes--it's no good to you, now--what do you keep it for?

SERGEANT: (still holaing the paw; looking at it). Fancy, I s'pose. I did have some idea of selling it but I don't think I will. It's done mischief enough already. Besides, people won't buy. Some of 'em think it's a fairy tale. And some want to try it first, and pay after.

(There is a nervous laugh from the others.)

MRS. WHITE: If you could have another three wishes, would you?

SERGEANT: (slowly--weighing the paw in his hand, and looking at it). I don't know--I don't know-- (Suddenly, with violence, flinging it in the fire.) No! I'm damned if I would!

(There is @ movement from all.)

MR. WHITE: (rises and quickly snatches it out of the fire). What are you doing? (He goes R.C.)

SERGEANT: (rising and following him and trying to prevent him). Let it burn! Let the infernal thing burn!

MRS. WHITE: (rises). Let it burn, Father!

MR. WHITE: (wiping it on his coat-sleeve). No. If you don't want it, give it to me.

SERGEANT: (violently) I won't! I won't! My hands are clear of it. I threw it on the fire. If you keep it, don't blame me, whatever happens. Here! Pitch it back again.

MR. WHITE: (stubbornly). I'm going to keep it. What do you say, Herbert?

HERBERT: (L.c., laughing). I say, keep it if you want to. Stuff and nonsense, anyhow.

MR. WHITE: (looking at the paw thoughtfully). Stuff and nonsense. Yes. I wonder--(casually) I wish-- (He was going to say some ordinary thing, like "I wish I were certain.")

SERGEANT: (misunderstanding him; violently). Stop I Mind what you're doing. That's not the way.

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MR. WHITE: What is the way?

MRS. WHITE: (moving away, up B.O. to the back of the table, and beginning to put the tumblers straight, and the chairs in their places). Oh, don't have any- thing to do with it, John.

(She takes the glasses on a tray to the dresser, L., and busies herself there, rinsing them in a bowl of water on the dresser and wiping them with a cloth.)

_Serczant. That's what I say, marm. But if I warn't to tell him, he might go wishing something he didn't mean to. You hold it in your right hand, and wish aloud. But I warn you! I warn you!

MRS. WHITE: Sounds like the Arabian Nights. Don't you think you might wish me four pair o' hands?

MR. WHITE: (laughing). Right you are, Mother!-- I wish--

SERGEANT: (pulling his arm down). Stop it! If you must wish, wish for something sensible. Look here! I can't stand this. Gets on my nerves. Where's my coat? (He goe* into the alcove.)

(Mr. White crosses to the fireplace and carefully puts the paw on the mantelpiece. He is absorbed in it to the end of the tableau.)

HERBERT: I'm coming your way, to the works, in a minute. Won't you wait? (He goes up o. and helps Morris with his coat.)

SERGEANT: (putting on his coat.) No. I'm all shook up. I want fresh air. I don't want to be here when you wish. And wish you will as soon's my back's turned. I know. I know. But I've warned you, mind.

MR. WHITE: (helping him into his coat). All right, Morris. Don't you fret about us. (He gives him money.) Here.

SERGEANT: (refusing it). No, I won't--

MR. WHITE: (forcing it into his hand). Yes, you will. (He opens the door.)

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SERGEANT: (turning to the room). Well, good night, all. (To Wuirs.) Put it in the fire. ALL night.

(Exit Szerceant. Mr. White closes the door, comes towards the fireplace, absorbed in the paw.)

HERBERT: (down 1.). If there's no mote in this than there is in his other stories, we shan't make much out of it.

MRS. WHITE: (comes down R.O. to Wurtz). Did you give him anything for it, Father?

MR. WHITE: A trifle. He didn't want it, but I made him take it.

MRS. WHITE: There, now! You shouldn't. Throwing your money about.

MR. WHITE: (looking at the paw which he has picked up again). I wonder----?

HERBERT: What?

MR. WHITE: I wonder whether we hadn't better chuck it on the fire?

HERBERT: (laughing), Likely! Why, we're all going to be rich and famous, and happy.

MRS. WHITE: Throw it on the fire, indeed, when you've given money for it! So like you, Father.

HERBERT: Wish to be an Emperor, Father, to begin with. Then you can't be henpecked!

MRS. WHITE: (going for him in front of the table with a duster). You young--! (She follows him to the back: of the table.)

HERBERT: (running away from her round behind the table). Steady with that duster, Mother I

MR. WHITE: Be quiet there!

(Herbert catches Mrs. Warts in his arms and kisses her.)

I wonder.? (He has the paw in his hand.) I don't know what to wish for, and that's a fact. (He looks about him with a happy smile.) I seem to've got all I want.

HERBERT: (with his hands on the old man's shoulders),

ALL: dad? If you'd only cleared the debt on the house, ou'd be quite happy, wouldn't you? (Laughing.' ell--go ahead!--wish for the two hundred pounds; that'll just do it. Mr. White. (half laughing). Shall I?

(He crosses to B.C.) Herbert. Go un! Heset--I'll play. slow music. (He crosses to the piano.) Mrs. White. Don't'ee, John. Don't have nothing to do with it! Herbert. Now, Dad! (He plays.)

MR. WHITE: I will! (He holds up the paw, as if half ashamed.) I wish for two hundred pounds.

(Crash on the piano. At the same instant Mr. WHITE utters a cry and lets the paw drop.)

cath a (together). What's the matter?

MR. WHITE: (gazing wuh horror at the paw). It moved! As I wished, it twisted in my hand like a snake.

HERBERT: (goes down R., and picks the paw up). Nonsense, Dad. Why, it's as stiff as a bone. (He lays it on the mantelpiece.)

MRS. WHITE: Must have been your fancy, Father.

HERBERT: (laughing). Well--? (Looking round the room.) I don't see the money; and I bet I never shall.

MR. WHITE: (relieved). Thenk God, there's no harm done! But it gave me a shock.

HERBERT: Half-past eleven. I must get along. I'm on at midnight. (He goes up c., fetches his coat, etc.) We've had quite a merry evening.

MRS. WHITE: I'm off to bed. Don't be late for breakfast, Herbert.

HERBERT: I shall walk home as usual. Does me good. I shall be with you about nine. Don't wait, though.

MRS. WHITE: You know your father never waits.

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HERBERT: Good night, Mother.

(He kisses her She lights the candle on the dresser, L., oes up the stairs and exits.)

(Com:ng to his father, R., who is sunk in thought.)

Good night, Dad. You'll find the cash tied up in
the middle of the bed.

MR. WHITE: (staring, seizes Hursert's hand). It moved, Herbert.

HERBERT: Ah! And a monkey hanging by his tail from the bed-post, watching you count the golden sovereigns.

: Mr. WHITE (accompanying him to the door). I wish you wouldn't joke, my boy.

HERBERT: All right, Dad. (He opens the door.) Lord! What weather! Good night. (He ezits.)

(The old man shakes his head, closes the door, locks it, puts the chain up and slipe the lower bolt, but has some difficulty with the upper bol?.)

MR. WHITE: This bolt's stiff again! I must get Herbert. to look to it in the morning.

(He comes into the room, puts out the lamp and crosses towards the steps; but is irresistibly attracted towards the fireplace. He sits down and stares into the fire. His expression changes: he sees something horrible.)

(With an involuntary cry.) Mother! Mother!

MRS. WHITE: (appearing at the door at the top of the steps with a candle). What's the matter?
(She comes down B.C.)

MR. WHITE: (mastering himself. He rises). Nothing --I--haha!--I saw faces in the fire. é

MRS. WHITE: Come along.

(She takes his arm and draws him towards the steps. He looks back frightened towards the fireplace as they reach the first step.)

Tableau Curtain. R '

SCENE II

Scunz.--Bright sunshine. The table, which has been nearer the window, is laid for breakfast.

MRS. WHITE: is busy about the table. Mr. White is standing in the window looking off x. The inner door is open, showing the outer door.

MR. WHITE: What » morning Herbert's got for walking home!

MRS. WHITE: (L.C.). What's o'clock? (She looks at the clock on the mantelpiece.) Quarter to nine, I declare. He's off at eight. (She crosses to the fire.)

MR. WHITE: Takes him half an hour to cha: and wash. Ho's just by the cemetery now.

MRS. WHITE: He'll be here in ten minutes,

_ Mr. White (coming to the table). What's for breakfast?

MRS. WHITE: Sausages. (At the mantelpiece.) Why, i* here isn't that dirty monkey's paw!
(She picks it up, looks at it with disgust, and puts it back. She takes some sausages in a dish from before the fire and places them on the table.) Silly thing! The idea of us listening to such nonsense!

MR. WHITE: (go up to the window again). Ay-- the Sergeant Major and his yarns! I suppose all old soldiers are alike--

MRS. WHITE: Come on, Father. Herbert hates us to wait.

(They both sit and begin breakfast.)

How could wishes be granted, nowadays? Mr. White. Ah! Been thinking about it all night, have you? Mrs. White. You kept me awake, with your tossing and tumbling-- Mr. White. Ay, I had a bad night.

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MRS. WHITE: It was the storm, I expect. How it blew!

MR. WHITE: I didn't hear it. I was asleep and not asleep, if you know what I mean.

MRS. WHITE: And all that rubbish about its making you unhappy if your wish was granted! How could two hundred pounds hurt you, eh, Father?

MR. WHITE: Might drop on my head in a lump. Don't see any other way. And I'd try to bear that. Though, mind you, Morris said it would all happen so naturally that you might take it for a coincidence, if so disposed.

MRS. WHITE: Well--it hasn't happened. That's all I know. And it isn't going to. (A letter is seen to drop in the letter-box.) And how you can sit there and talk about it

(There is @ sharp postman's knock; she jumps to her feet.)

What's that?

MR. WHITE: Postman, o' course.

MRS. WHITE: (seeing the letter from distance; in an awed whisper). He's brought a letter, John!

MR. WHITE: (laughing). What did you think he'd bring? Ton o' coals?

MR. WHITE: Suppose what?

MRS. WHITE: Suppose it was two hundred pounds!

MR. WHITE: (suppressing his excitement). Eh!-- Here! Don't talk nonsense. Why don't you fetch it?

MRS. WHITE: (crosses and takes the letter out of the bor). It's thick, John--(she feels it)--and--and it's got something crisp inside it.

(She takes the letter to WHITE, R.c.).

MR. WHITE: Who--who's it for? Mrs. White. You.

MR. WHITE: Hand it over, then. (Feeling and

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examining it with ill-concealed excitement.) The idea!

<What a superstitious old woman you are! Where are my specs?

MRS. WHITE: Let me open it.

MR. WHITE: Don't you touch it. Where are my specs. (He goes to R.)

MRS. WHITE: Don't let sudden wealth sour your temper, John.

MR. WHITE: Will you find my specs?

MRS. WHITE: (taking them off the mantelpiece). Here, John, here. (As he opens the letter.) Take care! Don't tear it!

MR. WHITE: Tear what?

MRS. WHITE: If it was banknotes, John!

MR. WHITE: (taking a thick, formal document out of the envelope and a crisp-looking slip). You've gone dotty.--You've made me _ nervous. (He reads.) " Sir,--Enclosed please find receipt for interest on the mortgage of £200 on your house, duly received."

(They look at each other. Mr. Wurre sils down to finish his breakfast silently. Mrs. Wurre goes to the window.)

MRS. WHITE: That comes of listening to tipsy old soldiers.

MR. WHITE: (pettish). What does?

MRS. WHITE: You thought there was banknotes in it.

MR. WHITE: (injured). I didn't! I said all along

MRS. WHITE: How Herbert will laugh, when I tell him!

MR. WHITE: (with gruff good-humour). You're not going to tell him. You're going to keep your mouth shut. That's what you're going to do. Why, I should never hear the last of it.

MRS. WHITE: Serve you right. I shall tell him. You know you like his fun. See how he joked you last night when you said the paw moved.

(She is looking through the window towards R.)

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MR. WHITE: So it did. It did move. That I'll swear to j : Mrs. White. (absiractedly : she ig watching some-

thing outside). You thought it did. _ Mr. Wars. I say it did. There was no thinking about it. You saw how it upset me, didn't you?

(She doesn't answer.) Didn't you?--Why don't you listen?

(She turns round.)

What is it? Mrs. White. Nothing. Mr. White. (turns back to his breakfast). Do you see Herbert coming? Mrs. White. No. Mr. White. He'

@ gentleman. Leastways, he's in black. - Wurrz. What about -him? (He is not interested, and goes on eating.) - Ware. He stood at the garden-gate as if he wanted to come in. But he couldn't seem to make

up his mind. Mr. White. Oh, go on! You're full o' fancies. . Warr. He's going--no; he's coming back.

MR. WHITE: Don't let him see you peeping.

MRS. WHITE: (with increasing excitement). He's looking at the house. He's got his hand on the latch. No. He turns away again. (Hagerly.) John! He looks like a sort of a lawyer..

MR. WHITE: What of it?

MRS. WHITE: Oh, you'll only laugh again. But Suppose--suppose he's coming about the two hun- dred-- :

MR. WHITE: You're not to mention it again!!-- You're a foolish old woman.--Come and eat your breakfast, (Hagerly.) Where is he now?

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MRS. WHITE: Gone down the road. He has turned back. He seems to've made up his mind. Here he comes!--Oh, John, and me all untidy! (She crosses to the fire BR.)

(A knock is heard.)

MR. WHITE: (to Mrs. WurtE, who is hastily smoothing her hair, etc.). What's it matter? He's made a mistake. Come to the wrong house. (He crosses to the fireplace.)

(Mrs. WurrE opens the door. Mr. Sampson, dressed from head to foot in solemn black, stands in the doorway.)

SAMPSON: (outside). Is this Mr. White's? Mrs. White. Come in, sir. Please step in.

(She shows him into the room and goes. He is awkward and nervous.)

You must overlook our being so untidy; and the room all anyhow; and John in his garden-coat. (Z'o Mr. White. reproachfully). Oh, John.

SAMPSON: (fo Mz. Wuirr). "Morning. My name is Sampson.

MRS. WHITE: (offering a chair). Won't you please be seated?

(SAMPSON stands quite still up o.)

SAMPSON: Ah--thank you--no, I think not--I think not.

MR. WHITE: (awkwardly, tryin7 to help him). Fine weather for the time o' year.

SAMPSON: Ah--yes--yes-- (A pause; he makes a renewed effort.) My name is Sampson--I've come--

MRS. WHITE: Perhaps you was wishful to see Herbert.; he'll be home in a minute. (Pointing). Here's his breakfast waiting--

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SAMPSON: (interrupting her hastily) No, no! (A pause.) I've come from the electrical works--

MRS. WHITE: Why, you might have come with him. :

(Mz. WurrE sees something is wrong and tenderly puts his hand on her arm.)

SAMPSON: No--no--I've come--alone.

MRS. WHITE: (with a little an. ety). Is anything the matter?

SAMPSON: I was asked to call--

MRS. WHITE: (abruptly). Herbert! Has anything happened? Is he hurt? Is he hurt?

MR. WHITE: (soothing her). There, there, Mother. Don't you jump to conclusions. Let the gentleman speak. You've not brought bad news, I'm sure, sir.

MRS. WHITE: Is he hurt?

(Sampson bows.)

Badly? °

SAMPSON: Very Ladly. (He turns away.)

MRS. WHITE: (with a cry). John--! (She in- stinctively moves towards WHITE.)

MR. WHITE: Is he in pain?

SAMPSON: He is not in pain.

MRS. WHITE: Oh, thank God! Thank God for that! Thank-- (She looks in a startled fashion at Mr. White--realizes what SAMPSON means, catches his arm and tries to turn him towards her). Do you mean--?

(Sampson avoids her look; she gropes for her husband : he takes her two hands in his, and gently lets her sink into the armchair above the jireplace, then he stands on her right, between her and SaMPson.)

MR. WHITE: (hoarsely). Go on, sir. Sampson. He was telling his mates a story. Something that had happened here last night. He

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was laughing, and wasn't noticing and--and--(hushed) the machinery caught him--

(A little cry from Mrs. Wurre, her face shows her . horror and agony.)

MR. WHITE: (vaguely), holding Mrs. Wurt's hand). The machinery caught him--yes--and him the only child--it's hard, sir--very hard--

SAMPSON (subdued). The Company wished me to convey their sincere sympathy with you in your great loss--

MR. WHITE: (staring blankly). Our--great-- loss--!

SAMPSON: I was to say further--(as if apologizing) I am only their servant--I am only obeying orders

MR. WHITE: Our--great--loss--

SAMPSON: (laying an envelope on the table and edging towards the door). I was to say, the Company dis- claim all responsibility, but, in consideration of your son's services, they wish to present you with a certain sum as compensation. (Gets to door.

MR. WHITE: Our-- great--loss-- (Suddenly, with horror.) How--how much?

SAMPSON: (in the doorway). Two hundred pounds

(He exits.)

(Mrs. White gives cry. The old man takes no heed

of her, smiles faintly, puts out his hands like a sight-

man, 'nd drops, a senseless heap 'o the floor.

Mrs. V : stares at him blankly and her hands go out help. _y towards him.)

Tableau Curtain.